

Fornication & Adultery

What's the difference and how are they related?

Definitions

Betroth/espouse

Deuteronomy 22:23

If a damsel that is a virgin be betrothed unto an husband, and a man find her in the city, and lie with her;

Luke 1:27

To a virgin espoused to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David; and the virgin's name was Mary.

Matthew 1:18-19

¹⁸ Now the birth of Jesus Christ was on this wise: When as his mother Mary was espoused to Joseph, before they came together, she was found with child of the Holy Ghost.

¹⁹ Then Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not willing to make her a publick example, was minded to put her away privily.

- Both *betrothal* and *espousal* are the social/legal equivalent to marriage. It is a custom.
- Note that the social/legal equivalent of marriage is **not** the same as marriage in God's eyes.
 - This distinction is most clearly depicted in two ways:
 1. The absence of any command for an espousal/betrothal period or a ritual or ceremony for marriage.
 2. **Genesis 2:21-24** and **Matthew 19:8-9**. Especially in how Jesus clarifies the only valid grounds for divorce to the Jewish audience: it is during the espousal/betrothal period before the couple become "one flesh".

Adultery

Leviticus 20:10 (violation of the marriage covenant)

Proverbs 6:29,32 (violation of the marriage covenant)

Matthew 5:32, 19:8-9 (an invalid divorce can result in adultery because the original couple is still married)

Romans 7:2-3 (violation of the marriage covenant)

Hebrews 13:4 (adultery is directly tied to a consummated marriage)

(many others; none of them definitively describe anything other than a violation of the marriage covenant)

- Any sexual violation of the marriage covenant. Requires at least one party to be married and as per **Matthew 5:32, 19:8-9** the marriage has been consummated.
- All adultery is a form of fornication.
- Adultery is a specific type of fornication.

Fornication

Genesis 38:24 (harlotry/prostitution)

Amos 7:14-17 (adultery; Amaziah's wife becoming a harlot is also adultery)

1 Corinthians 5:1 (incest/adultery/unlawful sexual relationships; **Leviticus 18:8, 20:11**)

1 Corinthians 7:2 (casual, non-committal sexual relations)

1 Corinthians 10:8 (**Numbers 25**; unknown; we can't prove if the perpetrators were married or not)

Jude 1:7 (homosexuality/same-sex sexual relations)

- Not all fornication is adultery but all adultery is fornication making fornication the broader "umbrella" term.

Physical fornication

1 Corinthians 7:2 Nevertheless, to avoid fornication, let every man have his own wife, and let every woman have her own husband.	Fornication is contrasted with marriage which puts casual sexual relations between unmarried couples under the umbrella of fornication (casual sexual relationships violate the command to “cleave to his wife” Genesis 2:24, Matthew 19:4-6).
Matthew 1:18-20 ¹⁸ Now the birth of Jesus Christ was on this wise: When as his mother Mary was espoused to Joseph, before they came together, she was found with child of the Holy Ghost. ¹⁹ Then Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not willing to make her a publick example, was minded to put her away privily. ²⁰ But while he thought on these things, behold, the angel of the Lord appeared unto him in a dream, saying, Joseph, thou son of David, fear not to take unto thee Mary thy wife: for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Ghost.	Mary is called Joseph’s wife before they became “one flesh” (came together; Gen 2:24). This is a tough situation because Mary is pregnant and yet no fornication occurred and Joseph and Mary didn’t have intercourse yet. Surely, Mary told Joseph what happened and how she got pregnant because otherwise it was grounds for divorce and even death as per the Law and it would have been a great dishonor for her. The angel of the Lord encourages Joseph to “take” her instead of divorcing her privately as he had contemplated. Joseph was obviously still on the fence over the issue of Mary being pregnant. If he truly didn’t believe her then as per the Law she was to be put to death. The angel of the Lord appearing to him in a dream settled any remaining doubt that Joseph might have had about how to handle the situation.
Deuteronomy 24:1-4 ¹ When a man hath taken a wife, and married her, and it come to pass that she find no favour in his eyes, because he hath found some uncleanness in her: then let him write her a bill of divorcement, and give it in her hand, and send her out of his house. ² And when she is departed out of his house, she may go and be another man’s wife. ³ And if the latter husband hate her, and write her a bill of divorcement, and giveth it in her hand, and sendeth her out of his house; or if the latter husband die, which took her to be his wife; ⁴ Her former husband, which sent her away, may not take her again to be his wife, after that she is defiled; for that is abomination before the LORD: and thou shalt not cause the land to sin, which the LORD thy God giveth thee for an inheritance.	A man may divorce a woman whom he has married and had intercourse with if he finds “<i>some uncleanness in her</i>”. Afterwards, if the divorced woman marries another man (and has had sexual relations with that man) and he divorces her or dies, the first husband may not marry her or have sexual relations with her again because that is an abomination. This teaches us that even among married couples, swapping husbands and wives via divorce and remarriage is an abomination to God.

Deuteronomy 22:23-27

²³ If a damsel that is a virgin be betrothed unto an husband, and a man find her in the city, and lie with her;

²⁴ Then ye shall bring them both out unto the gate of that city, and ye shall stone them with stones that they die; the damsel, because she cried not, being in the city; and the man, because he hath humbled his neighbour's wife: so thou shalt put away evil from among you.

²⁵ But if a man find a betrothed damsel in the field, and the man force her, and lie with her: then the man only that lay with her shall die:

²⁶ But unto the damsel thou shalt do nothing; there is in the damsel no sin worthy of death: for as when a man riseth against his neighbour, and slayeth him, even so is this matter:

²⁷ For he found her in the field, and the betrothed damsel cried, and there was none to save her.

If a betrothed woman willfully fornicates with another man they are both to be put to death.

If the betrothed woman was not consenting to the fornication (rape) then only the man that forced her is to be put to death.

Matthew 5:32

But I say unto you, That whosoever shall put away his wife, saving for the cause of fornication, causeth her to commit adultery: and whosoever shall marry her that is divorced committeth adultery.

If a couple is espoused/betrothed they are "legally/socially" considered man and wife. If one of them has intercourse with someone else during that espousal/betrothal period, God calls that *fornication* (not adultery).

Matthew 19:8-9

⁸ He saith unto them, Moses because of the hardness of your hearts suffered you to put away your wives: but from the beginning it was not so. (Deuteronomy 22:23-27)

⁹ And I say unto you, Whosoever shall put away his wife, except it be for fornication, and shall marry another, committeth adultery: and whoso marrieth her which is put away doth commit adultery.

Note that Noah Websters 1828 dictionary uses these verses to define fornication as "adultery" but these **are not** the correct verses to use for that definition (Amos 7:14-17 and 1 Corinthians 5:1 are appropriate). Remember that God is talking to a Jewish audience here and the covenant of espousal/betrothal is a very serious matter **to them** (it is not required by God). Therefore, Jesus lays it out to them as clearly as possible: the only time you can divorce without sinning is if either party fornicates during the betrothal/espousal period. After the marriage is consummated ("one flesh") it is **permanent**. The only way out after that is sin.

Moreover, if that divorced wife then goes and marries another man, God calls that adultery (because in God's eyes the original couple are still married).

1 Thessalonians 4:3-7

³ For this is the will of God, even your sanctification, that ye should abstain from fornication:

⁴ That every one of you should know how to possess his vessel in sanctification and honour;

⁵ Not in the lust of concupiscence, even as the Gentiles which know not God:

⁶ That no man go beyond and defraud his brother in any matter: because that the Lord is the avenger of all such, as we also have forewarned you and testified.

⁷ For God hath not called us unto uncleanness, but unto holiness.

Fornication is committed in the "lust of concupiscence".

The act of fornication is the same as defrauding a brother (a women that is meant to be married to someone else).

Fornication is uncleanness which is the opposite of holiness, sanctification, and honour.

The Lord will avenge any such dishonor.

Spiritual fornication

2 Corinthians 11:2

For I am jealous over you with godly jealousy: for **I have espoused you to one husband**, that I may present you as a chaste virgin to Christ.

- Paul himself could not perform the spiritual marriage operation (**Colossians 2:12**, **Revelation 3:20**) that only God can (**Ephesians 2:8-10**) but he could “commit to spiritually marrying” (espouse) a person to Jesus Christ.
- This process is commonly called “to proselytize” or “to evangelize” a person.
 - When we present Christ to a person they necessarily have to then make a decision: to accept or to reject Him.
 - That acceptance or rejection can never save a person (**Ephesians 2:8-10**) but it can open the door (**Revelation 3:20**) for the Spirit of Christ to do His mysterious work.
 - He will not force Himself on a person (**Matthew 23:37**, **Luke 13:34**).

2 Chronicles 21:5-13

⁵ **Jehoram** was thirty and two years old when he began to reign, and he reigned eight years in Jerusalem.
⁶ And he walked in the way of the kings of Israel, like as did the house of Ahab: for he had the daughter of Ahab to wife: and he wrought that which was evil in the eyes of the LORD.
⁷ Howbeit the LORD would not destroy the house of David, because of the covenant that he had made with David, and as he promised to give a light to him and to his sons for ever.
⁸ In his days the Edomites revolted from under the dominion of Judah, and made themselves a king.
⁹ Then Jehoram went forth with his princes, and all his chariots with him: and he rose up by night, and smote the Edomites which compassed him in, and the captains of the chariots.
¹⁰ So the Edomites revolted from under the hand of Judah unto this day. The same time also did Libnah revolt from under his hand; because he had forsaken the LORD God of his fathers.
¹¹ Moreover he made high places in the mountains of Judah, and **caused the inhabitants of Jerusalem to commit fornication, and compelled Judah thereto.**
¹² And there came a writing to him from Elijah the prophet, saying, Thus saith the LORD God of David thy father, Because thou hast not walked in the ways of Jehoshaphat thy father, nor in the ways of Asa king of Judah,
¹³ But hast walked in the way of the kings of Israel, and hast made Judah and **the inhabitants of Jerusalem to go a whoring, like to the whoredoms of the house of Ahab**, and also hast slain thy brethren of thy father's house, which were better than thyself:

- Here we see parallel phrases that tell us that spiritual fornication is the same as spiritual “whoring/whoredom” as in **Hosea 1:2** “*departing from the LORD*”.

Physical Adultery

Leviticus 20:10

And **the man** that committeth adultery with **another man's wife**, even he that committeth adultery with **his neighbour's wife**, the adulterer and the adulteress shall surely be put to death.

- Adultery is specifically sexual relations that violate the marriage covenant.
- Since both are required by the Law to be put to death then why did the scribes and the Pharisees in **John 8:3-6** not bring the man also?

Deuteronomy 22:22 (v23-27 cover betrothed virgins)

If a man be found **lying with a woman married** to an husband, then they shall both of them die, both the man that lay with the woman, and the woman: so shalt thou put away evil from Israel.

- God doesn't explicitly name this sin but based on the rest of scripture it would be called adultery.

Proverbs 6:29-32

²⁹ So **he that goeth in to his neighbour's wife**; whosoever toucheth her shall not be innocent.

³⁰ Men do not despise a thief, if he steal to satisfy his soul when he is hungry;

³¹ But if he be found, he shall restore sevenfold; he shall give all the substance of his house.

³² But **whoso committeth adultery with a woman** lacketh understanding: he that doeth it destroyeth his own soul.

- Adultery is specifically sexual relations that violate the marriage covenant.

Romans 7:2-3

² For **the woman which hath an husband is bound by the law to her husband so long as he liveth**; but if the husband be dead, she is loosed from the law of her husband.

³ So then **if, while her husband liveth, she be married to another man, she shall be called an adulteress**: but if her husband be dead, she is free from that law; so that she is no adulteress, though she be married to another man.

- Marrying another man, **whether she divorced the first one or not**, is adultery.

Hebrews 13:4

Marriage is honourable in all, and the **bed** undefiled: but whoremongers and **adulterers** God will judge.

- The marriage bed implies a consummated marriage and that is contrasted with whoremongers and adulterers (those who violate the marriage covenant).

Spiritual Adultery

Jeremiah 3:6-9

⁶ The LORD said also unto me in the days of Josiah the king, Hast thou seen that which backsliding Israel hath done? she is gone up upon every high mountain and under every green tree, and there hath played the harlot.

⁷ And I said after she had done all these things, Turn thou unto me. But she returned not. And her treacherous sister Judah saw it.

⁸ And I saw, when for all the causes whereby backsliding Israel committed adultery I had put her away, and given her a bill of divorce; yet her treacherous sister Judah feared not, but went and played the harlot also.

⁹ And it came to pass through the lightness of her whoredom, that she defiled the land, and committed adultery with stones and with stocks.

- Judah committed spiritual adultery with stones and wood (idols).
- They violated the spiritual marriage covenant between God and His people.

Ezekiel 23:36-37

³⁶ The LORD said moreover unto me; Son of man, wilt thou judge Aholah and Aholibah? yea, declare unto them their abominations;

³⁷ That they have committed adultery, and blood is in their hands, and with their idols have they committed adultery, and have also caused their sons, whom they bare unto me, to pass for them through the fire, to devour them.

- The symbolic sisters Aholah (Samaria) and Aholibah (Jerusalem) committed spiritual adultery with their idols.
- They violated the spiritual marriage covenant between God and His people.